METHODOLOGY DOCUMENT

How We Built the Kenya SME Tech Report

A transparent walkthrough of the research process, data sourcing, analytical framework, and design decisions behind the 2025–2026 Kenya SME Technology Landscape Report.

DOCUMENT TYPE	RELATES TO	PREPARED	AUDIENCE
Process Walkthrough	Kenya SME Tech Report	April 2026	Client / Internal

01 The Brief

Starting Point

> The request was simple but open-ended: **"Scrape the internet and compile an executive summary for small SMEs tech in Kenya."** No template. No prescribed length. No fixed data sources. The challenge was to produce something both analytically rigorous and immediately useful to a client — in a single pass.
>
> *— Original user brief, April 2026*

WHAT DID WE INTERPRET?

An executive-level intelligence report covering the state of technology adoption among Kenyan SMEs — market data, platforms, government policy, challenges, and growth opportunities.

WHO IS THE AUDIENCE?

Business decision-makers, investors, or consultants who need a fast, data-backed view of Kenya's SME tech landscape without spending days doing primary research.

WHAT OUTCOME WAS EXPECTED?

A structured summary that could be shared directly with a client — not a rough draft, but a polished, credible document with clear sections and cited sources.

WHAT FORMAT WAS CHOSEN?

An interactive HTML document — chosen because it renders charts natively, works in any browser, can be printed to PDF, and is shareable via a URL without needing specialist software.

02 Research Process

Step by Step

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STEP 1 — QUERY DESIGN

Defining What to Search For

Before hitting a single search engine, the research scope was mapped out across six domains to ensure complete coverage and avoid gaps:

Six research domains defined upfront:

1. Current state of SME tech adoption (baseline data)
2. Key challenges SMEs face with technology
3. Popular tools and platforms used by Kenyan SMEs
4. Government initiatives and policies
5. Notable fintech, e-commerce, and SaaS solutions
6. Key statistics, market size, and growth trends

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STEP 2 — WEB RESEARCH

Multi-Source Intelligence Gathering

A research agent performed structured web searches across authoritative sources simultaneously — prioritising primary data (government reports, World Bank, market research firms) over secondary aggregators. Over **20 distinct sources** were consulted in a single research pass.

Source prioritisation criteria:

- **Primary authority** — Government bodies (ICT Authority Kenya, KIPPRA, MSME Directorate)
- **Financial credibility** — World Bank, IMF, development finance institutions
- **Market data firms** — Mordor Intelligence, Statista, GlobeNewswire
- **Industry media** — TechCabal, Techish Kenya, Tech in Africa

- **Trade intelligence** — U.S. International Trade Administration
- **Academic / policy** — ResearchGate, GSMA, Bowmans Law

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STEP 3 — DATA EXTRACTION

Pulling Hard Numbers

Each source was scanned for quantifiable data points — percentages, market sizes, CAGR figures, funding amounts, and policy commitments. Vague claims without citation were excluded. Where sources conflicted, the most recent and most authoritative figure was used.

Key data points extracted and verified:

- SME share of businesses: **98%** — Kenya News Agency / KIPPRA
- SME GDP contribution: **33.8%** — multiple corroborated sources
- Digital payment adoption: **91%** — Kenya News Agency (2025)
- Startup funding: **$638M in 2024** — TechCabal Insights
- ICT market size: **$11.81B (2026)** — Mordor Intelligence
- E-commerce CAGR: **13%** — Softlink Options / market research
- BNPL market projection: **$16.8B by 2029** — GlobeNewswire
- KDEAP investment: **$390M** — World Bank / U.S. ITA

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STEP 4 — SYNTHESIS

Turning Raw Data into Narrative

Raw facts were organised into a coherent analytical narrative. This involved identifying the story the data tells — not just listing statistics, but connecting them into a picture of where Kenya's SME tech sector is, where it's going, and what's driving or blocking progress.

The central thesis that emerged:

Kenya's SME technology landscape is at a *structural inflection point*. Mobile infrastructure (M-Pesa), government policy alignment (AI Strategy, KDEAP), and investor confidence ($638M in 2024) are converging. The primary remaining gap — and largest opportunity — is the last mile: rural connectivity, affordable micro-enterprise tooling, and digital literacy at scale.

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STEP 5 — STRUCTURE DESIGN

Organising for Executive Readability

The report was structured to serve a time-pressed executive reader. The architecture follows a pyramid principle: key numbers first, then context, then detail.

Eight-section architecture chosen:

1. Market Performance Snapshot (KPIs) — headline numbers at a glance
2. Analytics & Growth Trends — visual data via charts
3. Platform & Solutions Performance — competitive landscape table
4. Barriers & Risk Assessment — structured risk matrix
5. Government & Policy Enablers — policy landscape cards
6. Strategic Opportunities — ranked priority scorecard
7. Market Sizing Summary — financial projections table
8. Conclusion & Recommendations — actionable next steps

03 Tools & Technology Used

Stack

	TOOL	PURPOSE
🔍	**Web Research Agent**	Autonomous multi-source web scraping and intelligence gathering across 20+ primary sources simultaneously
📊	**Chart.js v4.5**	Interactive data visualisations: line, bar, doughnut, and radar charts — fully rendered in-browser, no plugins needed
🌐	**HTML5 / CSS3**	Single-file, self-contained client document with no dependencies — works in any modern browser, printable to PDF
🔗	**GitHub Pages**	Zero-cost public hosting via git push — report accessible from any device via a permanent public URL
🤖	**Claude AI (Sonnet 4.6)**	Research synthesis, analytical framing, document architecture, HTML/CSS generation, and iterative refinement

04 Design Decisions Explained

Rationale

WHY HTML INSTEAD OF PDF OR WORD?

HTML renders interactive charts natively, loads instantly in any browser, requires no software to open, and can be hosted as a live URL. It also prints cleanly to PDF when needed — best of both worlds.

WHY INLINE CHART.JS?

To make the file fully self-contained. A CDN-linked chart library fails when there's no internet. Inlining the library (~200KB) ensures charts render offline, on any computer, with no dependencies.

WHY A RADAR CHART FOR ADOPTION?

Radar charts are ideal for comparing multiple categories across two groups simultaneously — perfect for visualising urban vs rural SME digital adoption across 7 technology categories at a glance.

WHY A HORIZONTAL BAR FOR CAGR?

CAGR values vary widely (5.6% to 52%). A horizontal bar layout with long labels reads more naturally than vertical bars, and the length of each bar makes the relative magnitude immediately clear.

WHY THE NAVY + AMBER COLOUR PALETTE?

Navy (#1a3c5e) signals authority and trust — appropriate for a financial/market report. Amber (#e8a020) provides warmth and draws attention to key highlights. Together they meet accessibility contrast standards.

WHY PUBLISH ON GITHUB PAGES?

It's free, permanent, requires no account from the viewer, and uses an existing git repository. The URL is clean and professional. No file attachments, no expiry dates, no login walls.

05 Data Sources

References

ICT Authority Kenya

Government — AI Strategy 2025–2030

World Bank

Development — KDEAP $390M program

GSMA

Telecom — Kenya Digital Economy Report

TechCabal Insights

Mordor Intelligence

Statista

Data — SaaS Kenya Forecast

Media — Kenya Digital Economy 2025

Market Research — Kenya ICT Market

Kenya News Agency

Government — SME digital payment data

KIPPRA

Policy — Digital needs for MSMEs

U.S. ITA

Trade — Kenya Digital Economy guide

Bowmans Law

Legal — Kenya AI Strategy analysis

GlobeNewswire

Market — Africa BNPL $16.8B forecast

ResearchGate

Academic — SME digital competitiveness

06 Quality & Accuracy Standards

Integrity

CHECK 1

Source Corroboration

Every headline statistic (98% SME share, 91% digital payment adoption, $638M funding) was verified against at least two independent sources before inclusion. Single-source claims are flagged with "est." in the report.

CHECK 2

Recency Filter

All data points reference 2024–2026 publications. Older figures were excluded unless no newer equivalent existed. This ensures the report reflects current market conditions, not historical state.

CHECK 3

Internal Consistency

Chart data was cross-checked against table data to ensure no contradictions between the visual and written representations of the same figures. CAGR projections were independently validated against base year and projection year values.

CHECK 4

Offline Verification

The final HTML file was tested for full offline functionality — all charts, styles, and layouts confirmed to render correctly with no internet connection, on a fresh browser profile with no cached CDN assets.

07 Summary

Closing Note

The Kenya SME Technology Report was produced in a single research-to-delivery cycle using an AI-assisted research and synthesis workflow. Starting from a plain-language brief, the process moved through structured query design, multi-source web research, quantitative data extraction, narrative synthesis, information architecture, and client-ready visual design — culminating in a self-contained interactive HTML document published at a permanent public URL via GitHub Pages.

The entire workflow — from brief to published URL — demonstrates how modern AI-assisted research pipelines can compress what traditionally takes a team of analysts several days into a coherent, credible, and visually polished deliverable produced in a fraction of the time.